

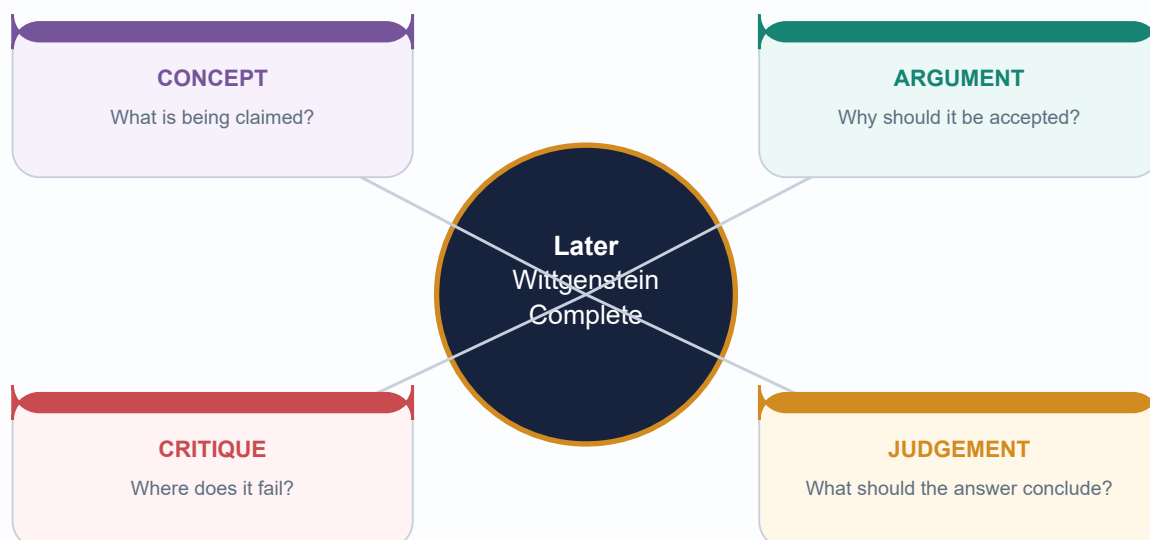
UPSC PHILOSOPHY OPTIONAL

Later Wittgenstein — Complete Visual Notes

UPSC Philosophy Optional • Paper I • Western Philosophy

Syllabus: Meaning and Use; Language-games; Critique of Private Language.

Direct local-book analysis • Verified knowledge cross-check • PYQ-mapped answer writing



Facts from official sources | Inferences clearly marked | No fabricated data

HIGH UPSC RELEVANCE

HIGH

Master Map, Context and Technical Vocabulary

Paper I Western
Philosophy

INTRO & ORIGIN

The Philosophical Investigations abandons the search for one hidden logical form: meaning is woven into public practices, language-games and forms of life, and philosophical problems arise when words are torn from their use.

Direct local reading: Warburton, Philosophy: The Classics, PDF pp. 408–432; Kenny vol. 4, PDF pp. 77–84 and 154–159; Cambridge Dictionary entry on Wittgenstein.

TIMELINE

1921/22 — Tractatus gives the early picture theory

1929 — Wittgenstein returns to Cambridge

1930s — Grammar, use and rule-following become central

1953 — Philosophical Investigations published posthumously

WHOLE-TOPIC DOCTRINE MAP

LATER WITTGENSTEIN

Use Meaning is a word's role within practice	Language-games Speaking belongs to diverse rule-governed activities
Form of life Shared human practices make rules and understanding possible	Private language Meaning requires public criteria and norm-governed correctness

KEY DATA

Term	Precise Meaning	Answer Use
Meaning as use	Meaning located in practical employment	Contrast picture theory
Language-game	Language intertwined with an activity	Give concrete examples
Family resemblance	Overlapping similarities without one essence	Explain anti-essentialism
Form of life	Background of shared practice	Ground public intelligibility
Private language	Purported words for intrinsically private sensations	Reconstruct rule and criterion argument

STATIC THEORY

- **Syllabus coverage:** Meaning and Use; Language-games; Critique of Private Language.
- **Intellectual context:** The Philosophical Investigations abandons the search for one hidden logical form: meaning is woven into public practices, language-games and forms of life, and philosophical problems arise when words are torn from their use.
- **Source discipline:** claims were reconciled with the verified topic note, recent PYQs and the directly read local books listed below.
- **Theme cross-check:** substance, a priori knowledge and critiques of metaphysics were checked where relevant.

MEMORY HOOK**U-G-F-P: Use → Games → Form of life → Public criteria.****MUST-KNOW FACTS**

1. Define each technical term before evaluating it.
2. Reconstruct the internal argument, not merely the conclusion.
3. Distinguish the thinker's own doctrine from a later label or criticism.
4. Use comparisons only after identifying the shared philosophical problem.

UPSC TRAPS**WRONG:** Meaning as use means any use is correct.**CORRECT:** Use is governed by shared norms and training.**WRONG:** Language-games are merely recreational games.**CORRECT:** They are patterned human activities involving language.**WRONG:** The argument denies private sensations.**CORRECT:** It denies a language whose standards are essentially private.**CROSS-SYLLABUS CONCEPT LINKS**

Core Concept	Linked Topic	Why It Matters
Picture theory	Early Wittgenstein	Trace the transition from form to use
Verification	Logical positivism	Plural practices replace one criterion
Other minds	Strawson	Public ascription and embodiment become central
Rule-following	Social philosophy	Norms depend on shared practices

MAINS ANGLE

Open with the problem that generates the doctrine; end by judging its explanatory gain against its strongest internal cost.

STUDY LINK

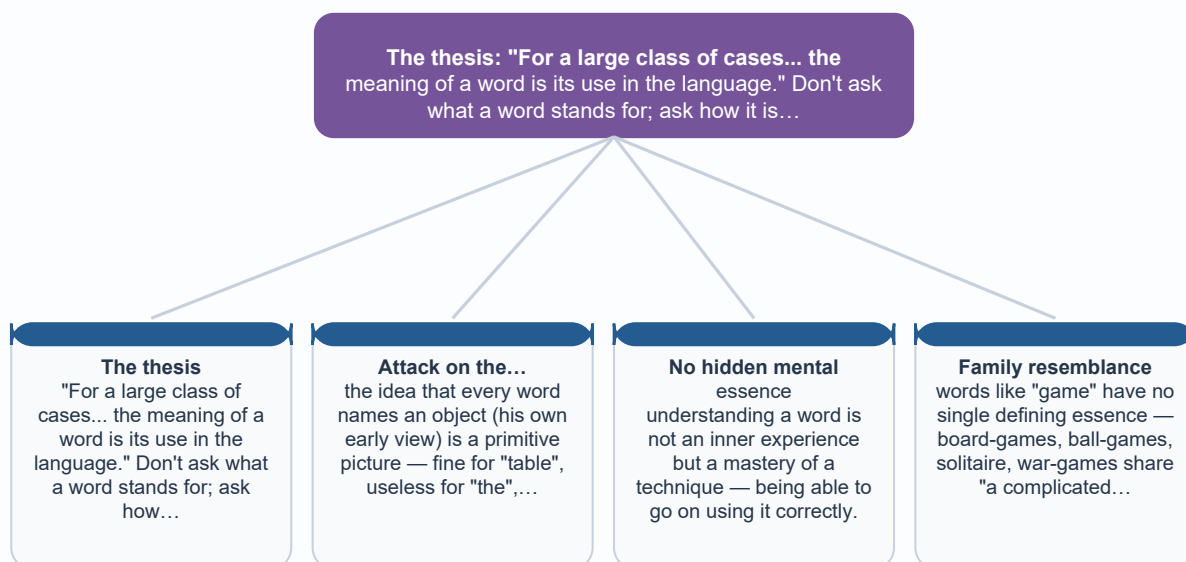
Direct local reading: Warburton, *Philosophy: The Classics*, PDF pp. 408–432; Kenny vol. 4, PDF pp. 77–84 and 154–159; Cambridge Dictionary entry on Wittgenstein.

HIGH**1. MEANING IS USE****Paper I** Western Philosophy**INTRO & ORIGIN**

The thesis: "For a large class of cases... the meaning of a word is its use in the language." Don't ask what a word stands for; ask how it is employed.

*Direct local reading: Warburton, *Philosophy: The Classics*, PDF pp. 408–432; Kenny vol. 4, PDF pp. 77–84 and 154–159; Cambridge Dictionary entry on Wittgenstein.*

1. MEANING IS USE — ARGUMENT / OBJECTION TREE



STATIC THEORY

- The thesis: "For a large class of cases... the meaning of a word is its use in the language." Don't ask what a word stands for; ask how it is employed.
- Attack on the referential/"Augustinian" picture: the idea that every word names an object (his own early view) is a primitive picture — fine for "table", useless for "the", "if", "five", "pain", "meaning". Words are tools in a box; their function, not a corresponding object, gives meaning.
- No hidden mental essence: understanding a word is not an inner experience but a mastery of a technique — being able to go on using it correctly.
- Family resemblance: words like "game" have no single defining essence — board-games, ball-games, solitaire, war-games share "a complicated network of similarities overlapping and criss-crossing", like features running through a family. Concepts have blurred edges, and that is fine. (Kills the Socratic demand for one definition — and the Tractatus's one logical form.)

MEMORY HOOK

U-G-F-P: Use → Games → Form of life → Public criteria.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. The thesis: "For a large class of cases... the meaning of a word is its use in the language." Don't ask what a word stands for; ask how it is employed.
2. Attack on the referential/"Augustinian" picture: the idea that every word names an object (his own early view) is a primitive picture — fine for "table", useless for "the", "if", "five", "pain", "meaning". Words are...
3. No hidden mental essence: understanding a word is not an inner experience but a mastery of a technique — being able to go on using it correctly.
4. Family resemblance: words like "game" have no single defining essence — board-games, ball-games, solitaire, war-games share "a complicated network of similarities overlapping and criss-crossing", like features running...

UPSC TRAPS

- WRONG:** Meaning as use means any use is correct.
- CORRECT:** Use is governed by shared norms and training.
- WRONG:** Language-games are merely recreational games.
- CORRECT:** They are patterned human activities involving language.

MAINS ANGLE

Reconstruct this section as a sequence of premises and consequences, then test the precise inferential bridge challenged by critics.

STUDY LINK

Direct local reading: Warburton, *Philosophy: The Classics*, PDF pp. 408–432; Kenny vol. 4, PDF pp. 77–84 and 154–159; Cambridge Dictionary entry on Wittgenstein.

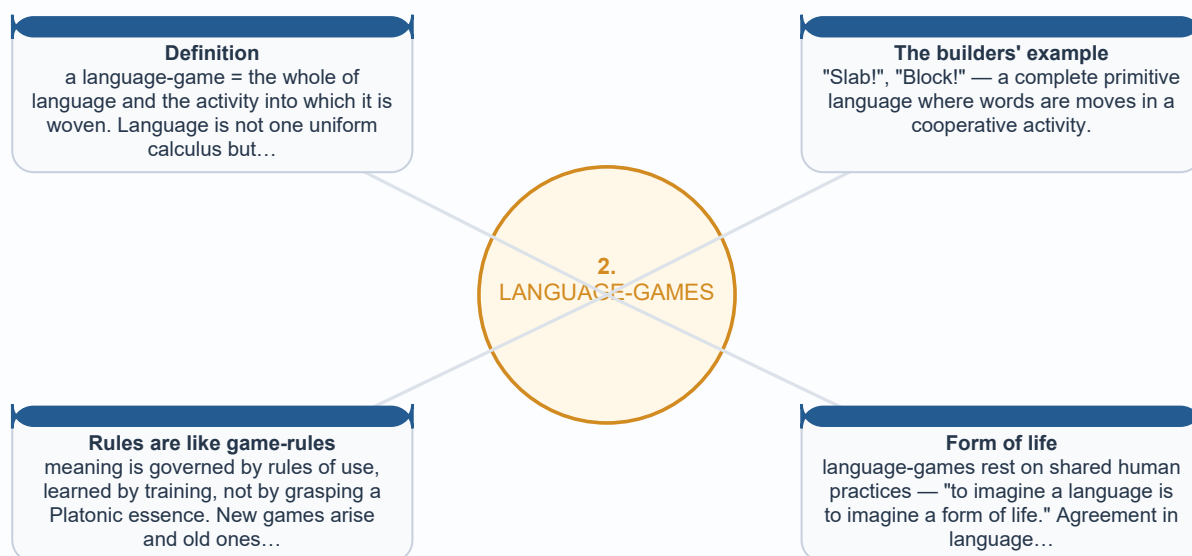
HIGH**2. LANGUAGE-GAMES**

Paper I Western
Philosophy

INTRO & ORIGIN

Definition: a language-game = the whole of language and the activity into which it is woven. Language is not one uniform calculus but countless different games — describing, commanding, joking, praying, thanking, greeting, guessing riddles, reporting, speculating.

*Direct local reading: Warburton, *Philosophy: The Classics*, PDF pp. 408–432; Kenny vol. 4, PDF pp. 77–84 and 154–159; Cambridge Dictionary entry on Wittgenstein.*

2. LANGUAGE-GAMES — CONCEPTUAL LANDSCAPE**STATIC THEORY**

- Definition: a language-game = the whole of language and the activity into which it is woven. Language is not one uniform calculus but countless different games — describing, commanding, joking, praying, thanking, greeting, guessing riddles, reporting, speculating.
- The builders' example: "Slab!", "Block!" — a complete primitive language where words are moves in a cooperative activity.
- Rules are like game-rules: meaning is governed by rules of use, learned by training, not by grasping a Platonic essence. New games arise and old ones die — language is a living, evolving practice.
- Form of life: language-games rest on shared human practices — "to imagine a language is to imagine a form of life." Agreement in language is agreement not in opinions but in form of life. Justifications end here: "This is simply what I do."
- Exam pivot: because meaning depends on the game, philosophical problems arise when a word is dragged out of its home game and misused ("language goes on holiday"). Philosophy = returning words to their everyday use = therapy, not theory. "Philosophy leaves everything as it is."

MEMORY HOOK**U-G-F-P: Use → Games → Form of life → Public criteria.****MUST-KNOW FACTS**

1. Definition: a language-game = the whole of language and the activity into which it is woven. Language is not one uniform calculus but countless different games — describing, commanding, joking, praying, thanking...
2. The builders' example: "Slab!", "Block!" — a complete primitive language where words are moves in a cooperative activity.
3. Rules are like game-rules: meaning is governed by rules of use, learned by training, not by grasping a Platonic essence. New games arise and old ones die — language is a living, evolving practice.
4. Form of life: language-games rest on shared human practices — "to imagine a language is to imagine a form of life." Agreement in language is agreement not in opinions but in form of life. Justifications end here: "This..."

UPSC TRAPS**WRONG:** Meaning as use means any use is correct.**CORRECT:** Use is governed by shared norms and training.**WRONG:** Language-games are merely recreational games.**CORRECT:** They are patterned human activities involving language.**MAINS ANGLE**

Reconstruct this section as a sequence of premises and consequences, then test the precise inferential bridge challenged by critics.

STUDY LINK

Direct local reading: Warburton, *Philosophy: The Classics*, PDF pp. 408–432; Kenny vol. 4, PDF pp. 77–84 and 154–159; Cambridge Dictionary entry on Wittgenstein.

HIGH**3. THE PRIVATE-LANGUAGE ARGUMENT**Paper I Western
Philosophy**INTRO & ORIGIN**

What is meant: a private language = one whose words refer to inner sensations knowable only to the speaker, in principle unteachable to anyone else (the Cartesian/empiricist dream of a purely private inner realm).

*Direct local reading: Warburton, *Philosophy: The Classics*, PDF pp. 408–432; Kenny vol. 4, PDF pp. 77–84 and 154–159; Cambridge Dictionary entry on Wittgenstein.*

3. THE PRIVATE-LANGUAGE ARGUMENT — REASONING SEQUENCE**1. What is meant**

a private language = one whose words refer to inner sensations knowable only to the speaker, in principle unteachable to...

**2. The argument (the "S/beetle"...****3. Suppose I name a private...**

"whatever seems right will be right, and that only means we can't talk about 'right'." Without a public criterion of...

**4. Beetle-in-a-box**

everyone has a box no one else can see; each calls its content "beetle". The word "beetle" has a use in the common language...

STATIC THEORY

- What is meant: a private language = one whose words refer to inner sensations knowable only to the speaker, in principle unteachable to anyone else (the Cartesian/empiricist dream of a purely private inner realm).
- The argument (the "S/beetle" thought-experiments):
 - Suppose I name a private sensation "S" and write "S" in a diary each time it recurs. To use "S" correctly I must re-identify the same sensation — but there is no independent check: "whatever seems right will be right, and that only means we can't talk about 'right'." Without a public criterion of correctness, the distinction between correct and merely-seeming-correct collapses — so "S" has no rule, no meaning.
 - Beetle-in-a-box: everyone has a box no one else can see; each calls its content "beetle". The word "beetle" has a use in the common language only if the private object "drops out as irrelevant". → meaning cannot be grounded in a private object.
 - Consequence: language is essentially public/rule-governed; a rule cannot be privately followed (that would be merely thinking one follows it). This demolishes Cartesian dualism's private mind, classical empiricism's private sense-data, and the referential theory of meaning in one stroke.
- The private-language argument is the jewel — it shows the inner/private is parasitic on the outer/public, inverting Descartes.

MEMORY HOOK

U-G-F-P: Use → Games → Form of life → Public criteria.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. What is meant: a private language = one whose words refer to inner sensations knowable only to the speaker, in principle unteachable to anyone else (the Cartesian/empiricist dream of a purely private inner realm).
2. The argument (the "S/beetle" thought-experiments):
3. Suppose I name a private sensation "S" and write "S" in a diary each time it recurs. To use "S" correctly I must re-identify the same sensation — but there is no independent check: "whatever seems right will be right,...
4. Beetle-in-a-box: everyone has a box no one else can see; each calls its content "beetle". The word "beetle" has a use in the common language only if the private object "drops out as irrelevant". → meaning cannot be...

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: Meaning as use means any use is correct.

CORRECT: Use is governed by shared norms and training.

WRONG: Language-games are merely recreational games.

CORRECT: They are patterned human activities involving language.

MAINS ANGLE

Reconstruct this section as a sequence of premises and consequences, then test the precise inferential bridge challenged by critics.

STUDY LINK

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HIGH

Criticisms, Replies, Comparisons and Verified Statement Bank

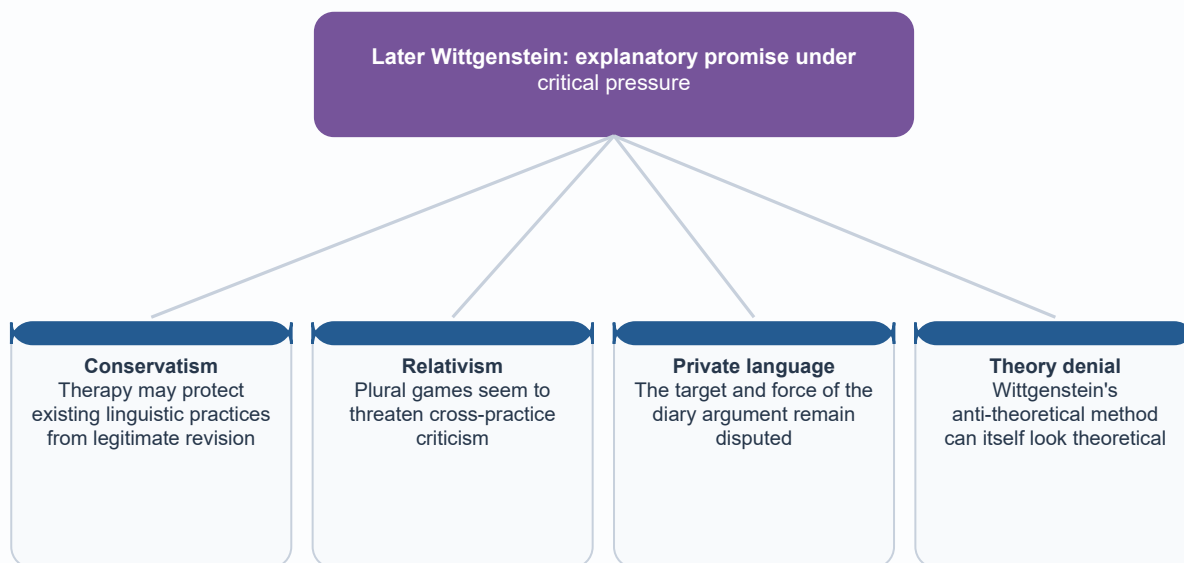
Paper I Western
Philosophy

INTRO & ORIGIN

A high-scoring critical answer distinguishes an external rejection from an immanent objection and gives the strongest available reply before judging the doctrine.

Statement bank retained only where the verified local topic file marks the wording as canonical; all other formulations are treated as paraphrase.

CLAIM–OBJECTION–REPLY ARCHITECTURE



KEY DATA

Axis	Later Wittgenstein	Early Witt (Tractatus)	Logical Positivism	Descartes/Empiricism
Meaning	use in a form of life	picturing facts	verification	idea/private reference
Essence of language	none (family resemblance)	one logical form	one criterion	naming
Metaphysics	dissolve as misuse of language	show what can't be said	reject as meaningless	pursue
Private inner realm	impossible	assumed	—	foundational (cogito)
Philosophy	therapy	drawing limits	analysis	system-building

STATIC THEORY

- **Critical pressure:** Conservatism — Therapy may protect existing linguistic practices from legitimate revision
- **Critical pressure:** Relativism — Plural games seem to threaten cross-practice criticism
- **Critical pressure:** Private language — The target and force of the diary argument remain disputed
- **Critical pressure:** Theory denial — Wittgenstein's anti-theoretical method can itself look theoretical

MEMORY HOOK**C-O-R-J: CLAIM → strongest OBJECTION → plausible REPLY → reasoned JUDGEMENT.****MUST-KNOW FACTS**

1. "The meaning of a word is its use in the language."
2. "To imagine a language is to imagine a form of life."
3. "Philosophy is a battle against the bewitchment of our intelligence by means of language."
4. "Philosophy leaves everything as it is."
5. "If a lion could talk, we could not understand him." (form of life)
6. "What seems right to me is right — and that only means that here we cannot talk about 'right'." (private-language)

UPSC TRAPS**WRONG:** Criticism means listing hostile names.**CORRECT:** State the objection's premise, target and consequence.**WRONG:** A quotation can replace exposition.**CORRECT:** Unpack the statement's technical meaning and argumentative role.**WRONG:** Comparison is two separate summaries.**CORRECT:** Compare axis-by-axis around a shared problem.**COMPARATIVE ROUTES**

Core Concept	Linked Topic	Why It Matters
Picture theory	Early Wittgenstein	Trace the transition from form to use
Verification	Logical positivism	Plural practices replace one criterion
Other minds	Strawson	Public ascription and embodiment become central
Rule-following	Social philosophy	Norms depend on shared practices

MAINS ANGLE

Use the statement as a compressed argument: define its terms, reconstruct what follows, stage the strongest objection and give a qualified verdict.

STUDY LINK

Verified knowledge file: [Later-Wittgenstein.md](#)
 • Direct local reading: Warburton, *Philosophy: The Classics*, PDF pp. 408–432; Kenny vol. 4, PDF pp. 77–84 and 154–159; Cambridge Dictionary entry on Wittgenstein.

HIGH**PYQs, Applied Drills and 10/15/20-Mark Answer Architecture**Paper I Western
Philosophy**INTRO & ORIGIN**

The final layer converts doctrine into directive-sensitive answers. Keep exposition proportionate to marks, reserve space for criticism and end with a qualified philosophical judgement.

PYQs reproduced from the local UPSC Western Philosophy bank for 2022–2025; wording is shortened only in the table, not altered in doctrinal demand.

RECENT DIRECT PYQ YIELD

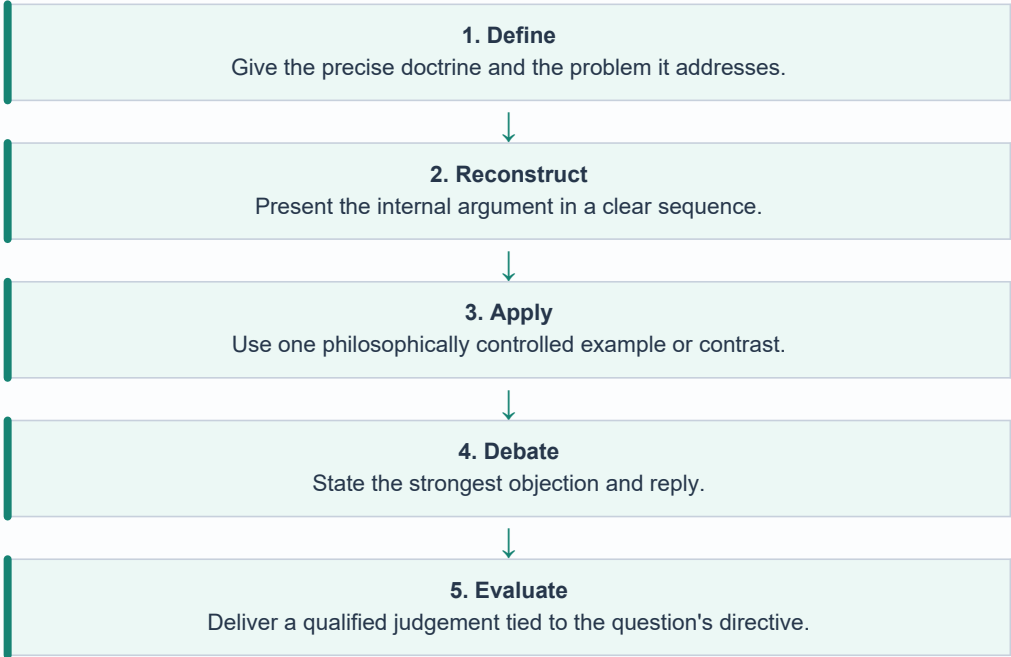


Bar length represents marks, not frequency.

KEY DATA

Year	Verified Demand	Marks
2025	Transition from ideal language to actual uses	20
2024	Why a private language is impossible	10
2023	Reasons for shift from picture to use theory	15
2022	Language as form of life	10

D-R-A-D-E ANSWER SPINE



STATIC THEORY

- **10 marks:** 2-line context; define the key term; 3–4 linked doctrinal points; one precise objection; 2-line judgement.
- **15 marks:** establish the problem; reconstruct the argument with technical vocabulary; add comparison or example; objection–reply; balanced conclusion.
- **20 marks:** map every syllabus dimension in the question; develop the derivation; compare alternatives; stage two critical pressures; defend or qualify; conclude with an explicit criterion of success.
- [Meaning] "'Meaning is use.' Examine Wittgenstein's later theory of meaning."
- [Turn] "How does the later Wittgenstein depart from the Tractatus?"
- [Language-games] "Explain 'language-games' and 'forms of life'."
- [Private language] "Reconstruct and assess Wittgenstein's private-language argument."
- [Family resemblance] "'Don't look for the meaning, look for the use.' Discuss with family resemblance."
- **7.1 — "'Meaning is use.' Examine the later Wittgenstein's theory of meaning." (recurring)**
 - Intro : reversal of the Tractatus — meaning is not picturing but USE.
 - B1 : reject referential/Augustinian picture; words = tools; family resemblance (no essence).
 - B2 : language-games embedded in forms of life; rules learned by training; philosophy = therapy.
 - Link : private-language argument secures the PUBLIC, rule-governed nature of meaning.
 - Assess: dissolves essentialism & Cartesian privacy; charge — is "use" too vague / conservative?
 - Concl : shifts philosophy from theory of language to description of practice.
- **7.2 — "Reconstruct Wittgenstein's private-language argument." (15m)**

MEMORY HOOK

MARKS CONTROL DEPTH: 10 = compact argument; 15 = argument + debate; 20 = complete architecture + sustained evaluation.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. The directive determines emphasis: explain, examine, compare and evaluate are not interchangeable.
2. A 20-mark answer must show relations among subparts, not merely add more bullet points.
3. Use one stable example through exposition and criticism where possible.
4. Conclusions should identify what the doctrine successfully explains and what remains unresolved.

UPSC TRAPS

- WRONG:** Memorise one essay for every wording.
- CORRECT:** Adapt the same doctrine map to the directive and marks.
- WRONG:** Criticism should occupy most of the answer.
- CORRECT:** Secure accurate exposition before proportionate evaluation.
- WRONG:** A conclusion merely repeats the introduction.
- CORRECT:** It must state a defended philosophical judgement.

MAINS ANGLE

For statement questions, treat the quotation as a claim needing reconstruction; for comparison, organise by axes; for 'does it solve' questions, state an explicit success criterion.

STUDY LINK

Official local PYQ bank:
[_PYQ-Western-Philosophy-2022-2025.md](#)